

Dhirubhai Ambani University

Elective Course: HM 413: Knowledge and Identity in Three Modern Indian Novels

An Open Elective Course for the Senior Undergraduate/Postgraduate Students in the School of Technology

Course Format: 3 Credits. 3 Lectures per Week

Prerequisites: An interest in the question of Identity, the traditional knowledge systems in India, along with some literary sensibility in the minds of the applicants for this course.

Course Content: This course has been visualised for undergraduate students without an intermediate academic background in the liberal arts stream. It aims to encourage and contextualize some of the natural questions that might arise in a young mind regarding individual identity, as framed in Indian traditions and knowledge systems.

This course belongs to the academic category of the Indian Knowledge System (IKS).

This course will examine the concept of individual/communitarian identity within the Indian Knowledge System, which originated in the Indian subcontinent and evolved over time through interactions with other schools of thought, facilitated by political and cultural exchanges spanning two thousand years. This question of identity and knowledge systems will be explored through its depiction in three iconic modern Indian novels: Saraswatichandra, Gora, and Aag Ka Dariya (River of Fire), written by Govardhanram Tripathi in Gujarati, Rabindranath Tagore in Bengali, and Qurratalain Hyder in Urdu, respectively. The course shall engage with their English translations, but students are encouraged to read them in their original versions depending on their competency in Gujarati, Bangla, and Urdu.

It is essential to note that the course will not focus on a close reading of the entire body of the texts to be studied, especially given the considerable length of the texts in question. The course will focus on the theme of the course as explored in the three novels rather than on the study of the literary aspects of the novels in their entirety.

Within this broad framework of the Indian Knowledge system, this course, visualised around the concept of Identity as imagined and defined in Indian knowledge system, aims to understand their relevance, as well as their outline, substance, and significance in a fast-changing present, and in the Indian context particularly, their epistemic position in the context of representation and participation across genders, classes and communities. The course also incorporates concepts such as truth, conscience, violence/non-violence, responsibility, and deprivation, from the perception of their specific natures in Indian

knowledge systems in interaction with modern thought, as depicted in these three important works by three influential figures in Indian literary history.

Primary Readings with a thematic focus

Govardhanram Tripathi, *Saraswatichandra*.

Rabindranath Tagore, *Gora*.

Qurratulain Hyder, *River of Fire*.

[Primary readings will be provided electronically at the commencement, and Secondary readings progressively during the course.]

LEARNING OUTCOMES: The course aims to acquaint students with the formative themes that these three thinkers/authors have explored and contributed to the modern concept of India, and to identify their central arguments about identity as defined within the Indian knowledge system. Students are encouraged to raise their individual questions regarding the art and arguments of these three authors.

COURSE REQUIREMENTS

Attendance and Participation: A minimum attendance rate of 60% is compulsory. The attendance policy will be strictly enforced, and students who fall short of the required attendance percentile will be subject to a grade reduction in accordance with the attendance policy. The success of the course depends significantly on students' engagement with the readings and with one another in class.

Mode of Teaching: The course will be organized around the concept of Indian identity as explored by the three authors chosen for study, and divided into four broad modules. The first module will consist of drawing the background of the course, identifying the main strands of thought emerging in modern India within the broad intellectual context of the meeting of cultures that took place in the Indian subcontinent in the preceding centuries, and defining the characteristics of Indian traditions and their knowledge system. The remaining three modules will be thematically centred around the three novels, respectively. The lectures will involve engagement with the themes, along with readings specifically focused on the central theme of the course.

EVALUATION: The first evaluation, in the form of multiple-choice questions covering the first three modules, and accounting for 30% of the total marks, will be conducted as part of the Second In-Semester examinations. Group presentations, to be made by students, will be scheduled during the last phase of lectures and will account for an additional 10% of the marks. Students are encouraged to make presentations based on their personal interpretations of the theme and content of the novels or create scenarios that relate to the themes of the three novels. The End-of-Semester examination, comprising multiple-choice, short-answer, and one detailed-answer question, will cover the entire course and account for 60% of the marks.

PLAGIARISM AND ACADEMIC INTEGRITY: Using words and phrases of authors without proper citation is considered a violation of norms of academic integrity and is strictly discouraged. Genuine effort and commitment will be duly appreciated.

COURSE OUTCOMES: The course aims to achieve the following outcomes:

- Introduction to Indian Knowledge System.
- Understanding the ethical human responsibility for nurturing a peaceful comity of races and communities.
- The novels to be studied reflect an understanding of knowledge as a repository, imagination, introspection, and evolution, and identity as a combination of a historical core and reflective process evolving through advancing knowledge arising from interaction among human communities. This concept of knowledge and identity forms an intrinsic part of Indian knowledge systems. Scholars and thinkers in India generally envisioned a universe intricately connected in both its creation and destruction. Therefore, all human activity was, in some way or other, part of this quest to discover the self and the world. Each individual developed with the support of others, whether it was visible or not.
- Knowing and understanding this fact was one of the highest functions of human consciousness. One should celebrate one's heritage, but should remain mindful of its universal human characteristics. Awareness of this fact is best reflected in the transcendence of chauvinism and intolerance, as well as in sensitivity to global ecological concerns, the commonality of concerns, and transnational moral claims to basic amenities across cultures. The course will highlight the importance of this formative and pervasive principle of life.
